Falling

By Deanna Jent

Suggested Roles: *Actor – Bill and Josh*
Actress: Tami and Grammy

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

(Pg 11-15) *Joshua enters the room. As he walks through the room, he occasionally pulls his shirt partially up exposing a nipple (one of his habits). Josh moves under the feather box, does a short ritual of touching certain things and moving in a certain way, and then dumps the feathers on his head. He squeals and is doing his happy dance as Tami enters carrying a laundry basket.*

TAMI: Hey, Josh – I like that smile! Remember, feathers go back in the box, please *(she exits)*

BILL: Feathers back in box please. Bus soon

JOSH: No bus. No thank you.

BILL: Feathers back in box.

JOSH: No bus.

BILL: Feathers in box. Bus at 7:45.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *The morning routine of a family coping with a severely autistic 18-year-old would be enough to exhaust anyone.*
ACTRESS: *But it is a daily reality for the Martins. In their home, the simplest of tasks –*
ACTOR: *getting ready for school,*
ACTRESS: *turning on blender,*
ACTOR: *getting out the door –*
ACTRESS: *are complex feats that require equal amounts of brute physical strength and relentless mental strategizing.*
ACTOR: *Routine is everything until a visit from Granny and a barking dog throw the tenuous equilibrium off kilter.*
TOGETHER: *Falling by Deanna Jent.*

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Josh makes a fist and pushes on his forehead between his eyes (This is a stress reliever) After a moment, he starts picking up the feather and putting them in the box. Tami enters drinking a cup of coffee.

TAMI: *(To Bill)* Smoothie time. *(To Josh)* Lisa is going to use the blender. We'll do "cover our ears" and then you can pick a game. Ready? *(Josh covers his ears with his hands and crouches)* OK Lisa! *(To Josh)* Here we go! *(Tami starts counting down on her fingers)* 5-4-3-2 and 1. Noise is all done. *(Josh pulls his hands away from his ears)* Good job! Now do you want to do "London Bridge" or "Big Bad Wolf"?

JOSH: *(excited)* And blow the house down!

TAMI: Alright! Dad – can you be a big bad wolf? *(Josh is excited)* Once upon a time there were three little pigs who went out in the world . . .

JOSH: *(Grabbing a finger with each word, hurrying the story along)* Straw, wood, bricks.

TAMI: OK! Aaaaaannnnd . . . So the three pigs were safe in their house of brick when along came the . .

JOSH: *(In a deep but no very loud voice)* Big Bad Wolf

TAMI: And he said:

BILL: *(In a deep voice, which makes Josh laugh)* "Little pigs, little pigs, let me in."

TAMI: And the pigs said . . . *(Cueing Josh)*

JOSH and TAMI: *(Together. High voices)* Not by the hair on my chinny-chin-chin.

BILL: *(Really getting into it)* Then I'll huff, and I'll puff, and I'll blow your house in! *(He blows as hard as he can, then stops)* Wait a minute, that didn't work! *(Josh nearly wets himself because this is so funny)* Let me try again. *(He blows and blows, until finally he "passes out.")*

TAMI: And the wolf blew himself out, and the pigs lived . . . *(Cueing Josh)*

JOSH and TAMI: Happy ever after *(Tami claps and helps Bill back to his feet. Josh is very happy, maybe squealing)*

TAMI: Yay for "Little Pigs!"

JOSH: *(Suddenly serious)* No bus. No thank you. No school

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TAMI: *(Cheery but not too loud playful voice as she tries to get Josh's backpack on)* Uh-oh! We can't change school days *(Exaggerated with a big gesture)* Rats!

JOSH: *(Mimicking her gesture and sound)* Rats!

TAMI: But after school, Grammy Sue is coming. And she is bringing a present for you.

JOSH: *(Looks out the window on the front door, in an animated voice)* Where is the bus?

TAMI: *(relieved, this is now part of the regular morning script – in a cheery voice)* I don't know. Where is the bus?

********** Scene break ************

TAMI: **(Pg 19)** So, um. Josh will be home soon, and I wanted to make sure you were ready. Did Bill tell you about how he gets upset sometimes?

GRAMMY: **(Pg 21)** You know our prayer group lifts up Josh every week. We have such a nice program for the disabled kids – I wish your church had one. **(Pg 22)** Josh is here for a reason God has a plan. **(Pg 21)** *(Josh enters)* Josh – come here and give Grammy a hug! I have a present for you. It's a puzzle with a train. *(Josh rips the paper off the box, examines it closely for a few seconds, then drops it on the floor.* **(Pg 23)** *He pulls up his shirt and touches both nipples)* Joshy, that's not nice. It's not polite to touch your chest like that. *(Josh continues as before. She speaks louder)* Josh!

BILL: Josh – shirt down. *(Josh pulls his shirt down)* Clap hands. *(Josh does)* Good job!

GRAMMY: You need to teach him to listen to other people. I told him it wasn't polite to have his shirt up like that and he just ignored me.

BILL: I'm sorry. He doesn't really get a concept like being polite. **(Pg 27-29)** *(We hear a dog barking outside)*

JOSH: Barking.

TAMI: Yes, there is a dog barking

JOSH: No barking.

TAMI: You don't like the dog barking.

JOSH: You don't . . . *(Tami interrupts him with sign language prompting the word "I")* I don't like dog barking *(He pushes his fist to his forehead)*

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TAMI: That's really good telling me how you feel, Josh. We'll help the dog stop barking, okay? Lisa? Can you put the dog in the garage while we eat supper.

JOSH: No barking!

TAMI: *(attempting to distract him)* Josh, It's time for supper. Do you want to eat with us?

JOSH: No supper! *(He exits back to his room)*

TAMI: *(to Grammy)* He likes to eat by himself. Or I should say, he doesn't like to watch other people eat. It grosses him out. Josh will be happy NOT eating with us, and if Josh is happy, then we'll all be happy! **(Pg 30-33)** Would you like to say the blessing?

(Josh enters and starts pacing back and forth moving between his happy dance and repeating a few lines of dialogue from a Tarzan movie. He does a "Tarzan" yell and a crash noise and the dog begins barking again outside)

JOSH: *(distracted)* Barking.

TAMI: *(Realizes this won't be a normal dinner, she attempts to diffuse the situation which escalates rapidly)* Josh, why don't you go read a book in your room and we'll take care of the barking dog. *(the following lines overlap at Josh's emotional level escalates)*

JOSH: No barking dog.

TAMI: I know you don't like the sound of the barking dog.

JOSH: Barking! Barking! Barking!

TAMI: I know! It is loud! Let's cover our ears.

(She covers her ears and tries to get him to cover his. Josh is finally at his breaking point and with a scream he lunges for Tami, one hand pressing on his forehead and the other grabbing her shirt near the neck. He pulls her close to him and screams again, then slams her against the door, his hands around her throat. Tami is working to pry his hands from her as she tries to talk calmly.) (To Lisa)

TAMI: Take Grammy to her room. *(Josh screams again and Tami continues speaking quietly to him)* Josh – look a Mommy. The barking is stopped the barking is gone.

JOSH: *(Screaming)* Barking! Barking!

TAMI: Let's breathe. *(She takes a deep breath in and blow it out)* Come on, sip a breath in. *(She sips like on a straw, and Josh does as well)* and blow it out. **(Pg 26)** Good! Now show me relax. **(Pg 33-34)**

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(They both blow. Josh is beginning to relax. He is still holding Tami by the shirt with both hands. Josh realizes what he is doing and begins crying a plaintive, sad howl. All the energy drains from him and he slides to the floor continuing his cry)

JOSH: I'm sorry. Mom I'm sorry Mom I'm sorry *(Sobbing)* Mom I'm sorry Mom I'm sorry.

TAMI: (Holding back tears and speaking over Josh's lines) I know you're sorry, Joshy, I just wish . . . *(The tears come)* you could be sorry before you grabbed. I wish you . . .

JOSH: *(Sadly)* Mom is crying.

TAMI: Yes, Mom is crying. . . *(She shakes it off and returns to her caregiver role but is still obviously shaken)* **(Pg 26)** Good job! Great relaxing Josh! Here are your choices right now. One: Watch DVD. Two: Play computer. Three: Do feathers. Which choice do you want right now? *(Josh frowns and shakes his head violently. Tami indicates the choices visually with her fingers)* One two or Three. *(Josh chooses silently by indicating with his fingers)* Good job choosing! You chose number 1. Watch a DVD in your room. Do you need some help?

JOSH: No help *(he exits)*

TAMI: *(to Grammy)* He should be fine now . . . **(Pg 35)** I know he's scary. **(Pg 36-38)** We have a hard time finding people who want to keep working with him. And really, he's calmer when it's just us.

GRAMMY: *(Completely shocked and appalled)* Isn't there some medicine that would . . . ?

BILL: *(as he comforts Tami)* He's taking three different things – if we up the dosages he just get more cranky.

GRAMMY: Isn't there a safe place that Josh could live. I thought now that he's 18 he could go to one of those group houses.

BILL: There's waiting lists.

GRAMMY: We can ask God for the solution. Can we pray together? We can pray for healing. For a miracle: that Josh will be released from this autism.

BILL: Mom – if you're gonna pray then . . . *(Not too fast, with conviction)* pray for programs and housing options and staff for people like Josh. Pray that our marriage won't fall apart. Pray that people will stop just praying and take some action.

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GRAMMY: *(offended, she begins to exit)* You know, when you don't want to pray is the best time to do it. *(Exits)*

TAMI: *(to Bill)* Wanna pray?

BILL: Not sure God wants to hear what I have to say right now. I just yelled at my mother and basically gave Him the finger. Got anything else you want me to screw up?

TAMI: You didn't screw up. She needed to hear that. You needed to say it.

BILL: *(Moving toward her)* I'm sorry. How badly did he get you?

TAMI: Not so bad. The shirt got the worst of it this time *(Bill comes up behind her and encircles her in a hug, which she accepts. He brushes her hair away from her neck and leans down to kiss her neck. She pulls away.)*

BILL: OK. Sorry. Just trying to take your mind off . . .

TAMI: I know.

BILL: You keep pushing me away.

TAMI: I can't . . .

BILL: What?

TAMI: I can't take care of another person right now

BILL: This is taking care of me?

TAMI: Isn't it?

BILL: I thought it was taking care of each other.

TAMI: I will fall apart if I let go. Why can't you . . . ?

BILL: That's the whole point. You let go and relax!

TAMI: That's why wine was invented! *(She crosses and pours a drink)*

BILL: So . . . you'd rather have a glass of wine than let me tough you.

TAMI: You know what? Sex is your prayer for a miracle – *(Gesturing towards Josh's room)* and look what that got us.

BILL: *(a pause)* I don't know what to say.

TAMI: Neither do I.

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AWARD HISTORY

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